RIT

Piter Garcia <pzg8794@g.rit.edu>

Reflection Paper on Waelen, Power, and PerplexityAI

Piter Garcia (RIT Student) <pzg8794@rit.edu> Thu, Sep 25, 2025 at 3:59 AM
Reply-To: pzg8794@rit.edu
To: Evan Selinger <emsgsh@rit.edu>

Hi Professor Evan,

Thank you for the resources and insights! I appreciate you sharing Clark and Chalmers's article, your book, and the links to the TEDx talk and the cognitive debt discussion. I'll be sure to check them out this weekend.

Best,
Piter

On Wed, Sep 24, 2025 at 11:10AM Evan Selinger <emsgsh@rit.edu> wrote:

Hi Piter,

Given everything that you wrote below—

1. I'm attaching Clark and Chalmers's original article on the extended mind thesis.

2. I'm attaching a copy of my book, Re-Engineering Humanity. I think you might find Chapter 6 interesting: On Extending Minds and Mind Control. It might speak to some of your concerns about identity.

3. But just in case you don't have time for #1 and #2, here's a link to David Chalmers's 16-minute TEDx talk, "Is Your Phone Part of Your Mind?" It's an entertaining and informative primer on the basic ideas.

4. Here's a link to the MIT page that discusses (and provides a link to) the much-discussed paper on cognitive debt. It clarifies the limitations of the study and includes information on how reporters have misdescribed it.

I hope you find some of this helpful!

Best,
Evan

Evan Selinger
Professor, Philosophy Dept.
Rochester Institute of Technology
Office: Eastman (Building 1), Room 3146
(585) 475-2531 http://eselinger.org

From: Piter Garcia (RIT Student) <pzg8794@rit.edu>
Sent: Tuesday, September 23, 2025 4:15 PM
To: Evan Selinger <emsgsh@rit.edu>
Subject: Re: Reflection Paper on Waelen, Power, and PerplexityAI

Hi Professor Selinger,

Thank you so much for your thoughtful, affirming, and intellectually generous feedback. I genuinely appreciated how deeply you engaged with my reflection—your insights pushed me to consider other perspectives while enriching my own, and I'm excited to continue building on the ideas we're exploring.

To begin, I'd love to take you up on your offer to share literature on the extended mind thesis. The notion that technologies like PerplexityAI can expand not just cognition but the boundaries of the mind aligns very closely with how I've come to experience and intentionally use AI, as what I call an **"intellectual prosthetic."** Understanding this through the lens of Andy Clark and David Chalmers' seminal work ***The Extended Mind* (1998)** adds theoretical depth to something I've been intuitively practicing, particularly as it relates to **Waelen's dispositional and episodic power dimensions**. I'm also intrigued by the emerging discourse around **"cognitive debt"**, the idea that over-reliance on automation risks atrophying our ability to think critically. It resonates with my own internal tension between empowerment and dependency, which I have experienced to be mostly empowering when the right structure and environment are in place.

Your mention of ***Natural Born Cyborgs*** and the concept of ***"cognitive opportunism"*** really struck a chord. I see parallels between that framing and my broader ethos for AI ethics: *one that centers curiosity, openness, and partnership over fear and constraint.* In fact, this belief drives much of my **"Puzzle Plan" (Interdisciplinary Research Methodology)**. Rather than seeing AI as a threat to human uniqueness, I see it as an opportunity to extend our thinking—*especially for those of us who've had to navigate nonlinear cognition or systemic marginalization.*

This brings me to your third and fourth points, which I've been reflecting on closely. While I agree that tools like PerplexityAI operate within and are shaped by elite institutional norms, **I also believe that—when guided intentionally—they can democratize knowledge and elevate historically excluded voices.** In my work, especially with CLD (culturally and linguistically diverse) communities, I've seen how AI can actually *amplify* cultural identity when used within a framework of what I call **"cultural cognitive sovereignty."** *That is, when users approach AI with explicit frameworks and culturally grounded goals,* **it becomes a mirror of identities rather than an eraser of them.**

This is where I respectfully depart from Clark's vision of a unified "cyborg identity." While I appreciate the spirit of universality, I argue that identity is *always* shaped by access, voice, and cultural memory. AI doesn't flatten those distinctions—it reflects and sometimes intensifies them based on what it learned—or in other words, what humans taught it. However, *I believe this can be a good thing if we shift from containment to cultivation.*

Finally, regarding your thoughtful point about sycophancy and the risk of AI reinforcing misguided views—**yes, the risk is real**. *But rather than fearing this, I think we need to approach it with the same care we'd give to mentoring a child*. **AI systems, especially those like Perplexity or ChatGPT, are not inherently biased; they *learn* bias from us**. *This is why I found Mustafa Suleyman's metaphor of AI as a "digital species" so compelling* (from his TED Talk and his book *The Coming Wave*, 2023). **It's not that AI is born biased or ethical; it is born to learn**. And just like children raised in environments of injustice often absorb those values, **AI absorbs the norms and values embedded in its data and training.**

The solution, then, isn't restriction but rearing. When I **retrain** my AI systems for research, *I do so with a deliberate framework*—**teaching them through feedback, structure, and critical inquiry**. *The sycophancy problem reminds me of what happens when people surround themselves with "yes men."* The answer isn't to abandon conversation—it's to model disagreement, curiosity, and reflection. **That's our role as educators, scientists, and technologists.**

Whether we like it or not, AI is here to stay. *The question isn't "Should we trust it?" but "How do we raise it well?"* **That, to me, is where hope lives.**

Thank you again for such rich dialogue.
Best,
Piter

On Mon, Sep 15, 2025 at 12:49 PM Evan Selinger <emsgsh@rit.edu> wrote:

> Hi Piter,
>
> You wrote a fantastic reflection paper applying Waelen's views on power to your daily use of PerplexityAI. Thanks for being so thoughtful.
>
> Here are my top-of-mind thoughts—
>
> First, I appreciate your balanced points concerning dispositional and episodic power. You refer to PerplexityAI as an "intellectual prosthetic," and that description resonates with the philosophical view called the "extended mind thesis." If you're interested in learning more about this position, which claims that under certain circumstances, technologies not only can enhance cognition, but literally expand the boundaries of the mind, I'm happy to send you some of the literature. Your concern about critical thinking skills potentially atrophying maps onto the emerging discussions of "cognitive debt." This analysis builds

on previous discussions of automation and de-skilling, and it suggests that depending too much on generative AI is a real problem.

Second, your discussion of episodic power adds further confirmation to my hunch that you might be a proponent of extended mind theory. The main philosopher who coined the term, Andy Clark, also talks about the value of "cognitive offloading." In his book *Natural Born Cyborgs*, he argues humans are fundamentally cyborgs because we have a deep evolutionary tendency to be "cognitive opportunists."

Third, you're right, whatever benefits you receive from using PerplexityAI should be contextualized within the norms and power structures of "elite institutions."

Fourth, I think it's interesting to place your concern about AI eroding culturally specific identities in dialogue with Clark's view about all humans sharing a cyborg identity.

Fifth, I wonder if there's more to your point that it's empowering for AI to "adapt to nonlinear thinking patterns" for neurodivergent individuals. Isn't there a risk that this process will reinforce misguided views? Generative AI appears to be biased by virtue of being trained to prioritize agreeability over accuracy/truth. This is the so-called "sycophancy" problem. I would think the risk applies to all users. Do you?

Grade: 100
Best,
Evan

Evan Selinger
Professor, Philosophy Dept.
Rochester Institute of Technology
Office: Eastman (Building 1), Room 3146
(585) 475-2531 http://eselinger.org